
User Experience Engineering

Milestone 1 - Resources

Resource: Sample Interview Protocol Template

This interview protocol was developed for a 15-minute interview with a user of GPS mapping applications, seeking to understand unusual or unexpected things about their usage habits.

Protocol

[Overarching Question]

What unusual or unexpected uses of GPS does the participant make when navigating from one place to another, especially in the context of informing new or improved GPS features?

[Introduction]

Hi, my name is Kentaro Toyama, and I'm here to understand better how you use GPS technology, particularly for navigating from one point to another. This interview will take about **10-15 minutes**, during which time we'll go through some questions. Throughout, I'd like you to treat me as if you're describing the situation to someone who isn't familiar with GPS devices. I'm here to learn from you.

A couple of things before we start. To the extent possible, I will take your comments to be **confidential**. My research team and I will aggregate all the comments from several interviews we're conducting so that your comments are not easily traced to you. If we quote you in our final report, we will do so without identifying your name or specific role. If there's anything you really don't want on the record, even if it's anonymized, please let me know that, too. Also, this interview is entirely **voluntary** on your part – if for any reason you want to stop, please let me know. We can end the interview at that point with no repercussions for you of any kind. I can also throw out anything you've told me until that point.

Do you have any questions for me? All right, then, let's proceed. [Once the interview gets underway...]

Oh, and by the way, do you mind if I take an **audio recording**? This is just so that I don't miss anything – no one other than the research team will have access to the recording. Thanks.

[Warm up]

How often do you use GPS for navigating?

In general, are you happy with GPS technologies?

[Recent use of GPS]

I'd like you to think back to the most recent time when you used a GPS to navigate from

one place to another. Can you tell me a bit about that trip?

[Follow up, if they don't include in their response]

- When did the trip take place? From where to where did you go? Roughly how long was the trip?
- When exactly did you turn the GPS on?
- How did you input the destination location? [E.g., by address, by landmark, etc.]
- Did you have to interact with the GPS once you set the destination, and if so, when and why?
- Did you have other passengers, and did any help with navigation?
- Do you remember turning the GPS off, and if so when was that?
- Did anything unusual happen on that trip?
- Would you say that that was a typical trip? If not, what was unusual about it?

[Repeat above, for other trips, if fruitful.]

[Unusual trip - if nothing interesting comes up above]

Now, I'd like you to think about a recent trip that was unusual or uncommon for you. For example, if you were on vacation, or in an accident, or part of a group of drivers going to the same location, and so on.

- Can you think of anything like that?
- What made the trip unusual?
- Did you use a GPS device? And if so, did the unusual nature of the trip change how you used the GPS?
- Who was in the car with you, and did they help with navigation?

[Other questions]

One of the things I'm most interested in are situations under which the GPS is used in an unusual way. Can you think of any instances when you used the GPS in a way that isn't typical?

- [Use follow-up questions from above.]
- Is there anything else that might be relevant – unusual uses of GPS, for example?

[Conclusion]

Thank you – those are all the questions I have for you. If anything else occurs to you after I leave, please don't hesitate to let me know by email. I may be in touch with you again to ask a few follow-up questions. If you'd like, I can send a version of the report that we'll write based on this interview. Do you have any questions? Thanks again!

Guidelines for Writing the Interview Protocol

Before you conduct your semi-structured interviews, you will need to prepare an interview protocol. In this milestone, you will write and submit the interview protocol for your interviews. Refer the Sample Interview Protocol given above to get a sense for what is expected. (Note, though, that that protocol was developed for a 15-minute interview. You will be conducting 1-2 hours of interview with observation.)

Write an introduction script. Generally, this will apply for all the protocols, and you can base yours off of the Sample Interview Protocol handout that is provided. The introduction script should include...

- A self-introduction
- The purpose of the interview
- What you will do during the interview and why
- Expected duration of the interview
- Confidentiality statement. The nature of this will depend on the user needs

assessment and whom you are conducting it for, but for this course, just relay general remarks to the extent that you will not attach personally identifiable information (such as their name) with any final outcomes of the project.

- Voluntary nature of the interview. Participants should be aware that they can quit or cancel the interview at any time.
- How you will follow up
- Permission to make an audio recording of the interview, if possible

Formulate one or two overarching questions. These will be the core questions you keep in mind throughout the interview. You should not have more than two overarching questions for your mini-project. (In bigger projects, you might have a few overarching questions, but even then, it is helpful to keep it to one or two.)

- Write 5-10 core questions (4 is too few; 20 is too many). Tips for core questions...
- Where possible, ask interviewees to talk through concrete instances, rather than asking generic, summarizing questions. "Tell me about the last time you performed this process," is better than, "Can you tell me how this process typically goes?" (You can ask the latter kind of questions, too, but don't forget to ask about specific instances.)
- Some of the core questions should prompt the interviewee the relevant work flow and talk through the process as you observe.
- For the core questions, cluster them by theme. Think about the ordering of the clusters, and also the ordering of questions within each cluster:
 - Topics should flow in a way that is easy for interviewees to follow.
 - Questions that are more open-ended should precede more specific questions about the same topic. This allows the interviewee to respond first with the way they think about the topic.
 - Questions that might be sensitive should be asked toward the end of a cluster, or even toward the end of the interview. If a question might erode rapport with the client, you want to do it later in a cluster of questions or later in the interview.
 - Sometimes, it's OK to say, "Let's switch to a different topic."

For each core question, write several follow-up questions. (Your grading rubric will be expecting an average of 3 or more follow-up questions per core question.) Include them under the core question in indented form, or as a bulleted list. These questions should help you do follow up, but if your core questions are good, the respondent will cover some on their own, and you may not need to ask follow-up questions explicitly.

Follow-up questions are meant to fill holes in information, or to hear more about interesting issues that the interviewee raises. The goal is either to make sure the interviewee has really addressed the core question to your satisfaction, or to follow up on leads that you may not have anticipated, but which are relevant to the problem.

Write a conclusion script.

Avoiding Common Pitfalls

Throughout the protocol, avoid these common errors:

- Including too many closed-ended, short-answer questions. If most of your questions are closed-ended, you will have a short interview in which you learn very little. (However, it's OK to have some short-answer questions, especially during warm up, or when you need concrete information to ask an open-ended follow-up question.)
- Asking about basic information that you could have easily found out through other means, such as an online search.
- Asking irrelevant questions that don't contribute to the overarching question, or which aren't pertinent to your understanding of the problem.
- Not asking about specific, concrete instances. It's OK to have some questions that ask interviewees to summarize what they know, but ask such questions after you've asked them about a concrete instance of the situation. (People often do not summarize accurately, and summaries in interviews are not as credible as concrete information. It's your job to summarize during analysis.)
- Adopting a tone that could be interpreted as doubting the interviewee, or evaluating the interviewee's competence. "Why isn't this a problem you can solve by looking up online help?" could sound accusatory. A better way to phrase this question is, "When you encounter obstacles like this, how do you go about addressing them?"
- Asking leading questions that include an assumption that may not be true, or which influence the interviewee to answer in a particular way. Examples...
 - "Is it because of a bad process that this task is difficult?"
 - Instead, try: "What do you think makes this task difficult?"
 - "Isn't this a poor user interface?"
 - Instead, try: "Is this user interface good or bad?"
 - Even better: "What do you think of this user interface, and why?"
- Write a conclusion script.
 - Ask them if they have any other things to tell you. Let them know the interview is over. Thank the interviewee. Let them know what will happen next. Again, feel free to use the Sample Interview Protocol as a template.